Natron

A powerful digital compositing software that is industry grade and yet open source

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Natron is a software that can integrate perfectly into your video production workflow, and is really good at performing compositing tasks such as masking, tracking, and rotoscoping. One of the good things about Natron is that it is completely open source, and supports scripting in Python so you can get down and dirty with the inner workings of the software if you are so inclined. Additionally Natron has a kind and helpful community, plenty of tutorial videos on YouTube and most importantly, a large library of community made plugins that seriously expand the capabilities of the software far beyond the base installation.

ADD A GREEN SCREEN EFFECT

One of the basic and essential compositing techniques is that of removing a background from a video, that is colloquially known as greenscreening and within the industry as chroma keying. Here, you will need the video already shot, where the background is in one single colour, usually green or blue. You will also need a background video to overlay this green-screened image onto. Natron works by piping the content through a series of nodes, each of which adds an effect or changes the video in some way. The first node we will need is the Viewer, which displays the final output of the video at the end of all the processing pipelines. Now it is very important to connect the arrows to the right nodes to get the desired effect, or else there can be funny accidents such as the background appearing as a layer over the cut out object to be greenscreened. The various nodes are available in the hexagonal tools on the toolbar to the right. First we will need to add videos to the pipeline. This is a node that you will be using whenever you are working with a video on Natron. The node is known as Player, and is available on the first button of the toolbar. You will need two players for the foreground and background videos, so this node has to be added twice into the project. At the time of adding the Player nodes into the project, you have to navigate through the file system, and pick the video asset that the particular player node will use. Here, in one Player node, load the foreground video, and in another player node, the background video. Next, we will need to combine the two layers into a single video, which is why we will need the Merge node, which is in the menu option with the layers icon. Now we need the node where the greenscreening actually happens, and this one is called the ChromaKeyer node, which is available in the menu icon with the eyedropper tool. Double click on the node to get the node controls, and in the panel on the top right you will see the options for picking the colour directly from a colour wheel, or using an eyedropper to pick the colour from the video itself. Note that to use the eye dropper, it is necessary to Ctrl+click the colour, and the software prompts you with the precise steps needed for the task if you hover over the eyedropper tool. Every time you get stuck or wonder what a particular button does, hov-